emerged from political hibernation to found the Armed Reserve Force, along with his close friend Abdul Majid Dar, who would go on to become Commander-in-Chief (Operations) in the Hizb-ul-Mujahideen. Qureshi was once again detained under the Terrorist and Disruptive Activities (Prevention) Act in February 1990 and released on 3 June 1992. Qureshi founded the PPF on 8 August 1993. Of those Al-Fatah members opposed to the Indira-Abdullah accord of 1975, the key ones—Nazir Ahmed Wani, Hamidullah Bhat and Mohammad Shaban Vakil—were party to the decision to revive Al-Fatah on 14 September 1991. Abu Khalid was made its new chief. Soon after its revival in the valley, the group claimed responsibility for the abduction of a French engineer, Silva Antonia, in the Doda district on 14 October 1991. Abu Khalid, talking of the need to revive the organisation, said that the old stalwarts had decided to make their contribution to the achievement of the right of self-determination. In October 1994, the SOG of the Jammu and Kashmir Police killed three Al-Fatah terrorists in a joint operation with the 26 Punjab Regiment at Koil Muqam and Malangam.[8]

The moot question is—was the split in Al-Fatah a genuine split or was it an engineered split to once again send agent provocateurs or ‘transients’ into the ‘twilight zone’? The Al-Fatah story reveals the limitations of the process of political accommodation of violent secessionists and their induction into the mainstream. The unanswered question is—were there channels of communication and control between the National Conference and the breakaway group of Al-Fatah after 1975? Was Fazl-ul-Qureshi this link? Was his action of founding the Armed Reserve Force, along with Abdul Majid Dar, and its absorption into the Hizb-ul-Mujahideen, an act of extending the shadows of the ‘twilight zone’ into an overlap between Pakistan controlled non-state actors? And in this saga, the final question that emerges is—was the air crash that killed Surendra Nath, a former IPS officer, and in 1994 the Governor of Punjab, actually a political assassination executed by the ISI? Governor Nath was in the crosshairs of the ISI because he had exposed their duplicity in the valley and in Punjab. Perhaps it is time for the Government of India to revisit his seminal report